ANI



NEW COMPANY TMC MPs meet Lok Sabha speaker Om Birla on June 14

Each one left years on the table. And because the BJP now holds a brute majority in the assembly seats that elect the Rajya Sabha members, it can take all three vacated seats whenever the bypolls are held, turning three resignations into three near-certain gains.

The same tactics had already been used on the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP). In April, seven of its 10 Rajya Sabha MPs, led by Raghav Chadha, resigned and joined the BJP, again invoking the merger clause on the grounds that two-thirds of the members had moved together. AAP's Sanjay Singh has filed a disqualification plea before Rajya Sabha chairman C.P. Radhakrishnan, arguing that the clause requires the original party to merge, not merely its legislators in one House. But there is no deadline for a ruling.

The Opposition's 'loosening' grip is evident in the South as well, though there it pulls in more than one direction. In Tamil Nadu, the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) has put distance between itself and a BJP that many in its ranks blame for blurring the party's identity and the election wipeout. The Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), with 22 seats in the Lok Sabha and 10 in the Rajya Sabha, is the third-largest Opposition presence in the Lower House, but it has its own worries. The party has yet to come to terms with long-time ally Congress ditching it to partner with actor Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam government. Indeed, it now says it is not part of the INDIA bloc anymore. The result has been a softer posture toward the Centre that would have looked impossible even six months ago. The old certainties that organised the coalition era are coming undone, and the Opposition's trust is fraying from within as much as from outside.

BENGAL APART, THE BJP HASN'T ENLARGED ITS OWN FOOTPRINT MUCH. IT HAS INSTEAD GATHERED UP THE FRAGMENTS AROUND IT

What does all this add up to? For an ordinary legislation, the gains are already decisive for the BJP. The Lok Sabha bloc, with the Trinamool and possible six Sena (UBT) defectors counted in, climbs to around 319, and the Upper House majority of about 148 could end a decade in which the government could be stalled by the Opposition's numbers.

TARGET: SUPER MAJORITY

A constitutional amendment, though, is a higher wall to climb. Article 368 demands not just a majority of each House's total strength but two-thirds of those present and voting, which works out to 363 votes in a full Lok Sabha and 164 in the Rajya Sabha. So, the shifts can be read two ways. The first is preparatory. Brick by brick, the ruling alliance is building towards a super majority that delimitation, simultaneous elections and other long-promised amendments would require, narrowing a gap it could not close at the hustings. The second is attritional. Short of that threshold, the steady stripping of MPs from the TMC, AAP and perhaps the Sena (UBT) next works as a kind of psychological warfare, hollowing out rival parties, sapping their cadre and denying the Opposition the cohesion it briefly found in April.

The work is already half done. The Shiv Sena and Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) have split, the YSRCP has collapsed at the polls, the BRS is diminished, the TMC has lost Bengal and is shedding MPs, AAP has lost Delhi and also two-thirds of its RS bench, Tamil Nadu's alignments are in a flux. But even so, Bengal apart, the BJP has not greatly enlarged its own footprint. It has instead gathered up the fragmentation around it, using a merger clause it is well-placed to exploit, and petitions its own nominees are positioned to decide.

The 2024 verdict produced a coalition government with limits, and the floor of the House proved as much in April. The months since have been spent chipping away at those limits by other means, seat by seat and defection by defection, to now when the Opposition struggles to hold on to its own members. By the time the monsoon session opens, the numbers in Parliament will have moved, and so will the equations between the parties. All this without the voters being asked again to make their choice. ■